

Practicing Mindfulness of Emotions at Home

Set aside a few minutes when you can be quiet and won't be disturbed.

Start by bringing your attention to your breath. Notice your breathing as you slowly breathe in and out, perhaps imagining you have a balloon in your belly, noticing the sensations in your belly as the balloon inflates on the in-breath, and deflates on the out-breath. Or simply observe the physical sensations of breath at the tip of the nostrils – feel the coolness of the air on the in-breath and warmth of the air on the outbreath. Or feel the chest rising on the in-breath and lowering on the outbreath...notice the sensations in the front and sides of your chest moving.



Notice the feelings, and what it **feels** like in terms of bodily sensations. **Write out your answers below:**



Name the emotion:

- What word best describes what you are feeling? What feeling is most pre-dominant? _____
i.e. Angry, sad, anxious, irritated, scared, frustrated... Naming it is an important step. If you're not exactly sure which one(s) it is, is it pleasant or unpleasant?

Choose to **Accept** the emotion, i.e. 'It's okay to feel this. It's already here. I can breathe with this'. It's a normal body reaction. It can be helpful to understand how it came about – what it was, the set of circumstances that contributed to you feeling this way. Don't condone or judge the emotion. Simply let it move through you without resisting it, struggling against it, or encouraging it.

Investigate the emotion with **non-judgment, curiosity** and **gentleness**.

- How intensely do you feel it? _____
- How are you breathing? (note the qualities: short and shallow, long and full, rapid and choppy) _____
- What are you feeling in your body? Where do you feel it? _____
- What's your posture like when you feel this emotion? _____
- Where do you notice muscle tension? _____
- What's your facial expression? What does your face feel like? _____

Breathe into and out from the area that is experiencing tightness, heaviness, or other sensations. Invite the area to soften on the outbreath, even a little.

- Is anything changing? (nature, position, intensity) Is it staying the same? Simply notice and **allow**. _____

What thoughts or judgements do you notice? Just notice those thoughts. **Allow them to come into your mind, and allow them to pass.** Any time you find that you're engaging with the thoughts – judging them or yourself for having them, believing them, struggling against them, just notice, and bring your attention back to your breathing, and to the physical sensations of the emotion. _____

If any other emotions come up, if anything changes, simply notice and repeat the steps above. Just **notice that the feelings change** over time. Notice the **impermanence** of thoughts/feelings/sensations. As you become more practised, you can use this mindfulness technique when you feel more intense emotion.